

In computer technology, a ROM stands for Read Only Memory, a section of memory that cannot be written into, and stores important firmware that is read from during the boot process. However, in the Android community, the meaning of a ROM is quite different, and the term is used to refer to the image of the OS that your phone runs. These ‘images’ are all based on the original (or ‘stock’) Android system provided and open sourced by Google. Different developers add (or sometimes remove) components to tweak the performance of the device running Android. Android ROMs are treasured by the community as they unlock features previously locked down by the manufacturer (or at times, the wireless carrier), remove crapware installed by OEMs and provide significant performance enhancements, giving a new lease of life to older devices. The process of installing an Android ROM is called ‘flashing’, and will in most cases void your warranty. Needless to say, one needs to exercise caution in attempting to flash a ROM. If done correctly though, a custom ROM can make using your device a joyride.

Custom ROMs for Android, as you might’ve guessed are a dime a dozen. There exist literally hundreds of ROMs, each boasting of a particular feature such as a lower system footprint, added features and apps, better aesthetics in the UI, or a mixture of all three. These are analogous to Linux distributions, where the ability to openly modify and redistribute the source code has resulted in a number of flavours of Linux. Two of the most popular ROMs are Cyanogenmod and MIUI, where the former focuses on speed and featured, the latter sports a gorgeous interface and some beautiful stock apps.

Due to the wide range of devices with different internal hardware and screen sizes, there is no universal firmware when it comes to Android. ROMs are always catered to specific device models, and you can seri-



Cyanogenmod lets you easily tweak your phone